

shirt. Three buttons are undone over a hairy chest, which I find myself, very primly, very Englishly, trying not to look at for two and a half hours.

It's midday now (Ford's least-favourite time for being seen out and about—the unflattering shadows), but somehow he has arranged the atmospherics in this fancily decorated, windowless boîte so that it could be any time of night. This is oh-so Tom Ford of old, and this is not our first rodeo. I first interviewed him back in 1994, the season before his smash-hit Gucci velvet boot-cut hipsters and slinky silk blouse collection upturned boring minimalist fashion. It made his name, setting off all the incendiary sex-and-glamour sensations that put his stamp on the late Nineties and Noughties.

Gucci had very little money at the beginning, but looking back — and also projecting forward to the movie-maker Ford is today—there was always something cinematic about the staging of those shows, down to how he rigged a single spotlight to pick out the girls in an always darkened space. "Shows are cinematic. You introduce the audience to something new. Act I, jolt them. Act II, talk them through it. Act III, resolve it. And they should leave in tears! Moved by emotion. That's why I could never show in the day. It's too bright! You can't control it!"

"We can talk as long as you like," he offers, urbanely.



